The views of the Indian media reflected official Indian thinking on these foreign policy issues. On 21 October 1994, for instance, the *Times of India* sought a 'reassessment' of India's 'hands-off approach' and advocated an active policy of India providing a 'neutral' platform to the warring factions.[151] Throughout 1995, the *Times of India* gave a blanket assessment of ISI-Taliban nexus and claimed that 'working under the guise of bringing peace to a war-ravaged countryside through the strict implementation of the Shariat, the ISI has sought to further its own agenda'.[152] They also called Hekmatyar a 'Frankenstein's monster' created and nourished by Pakistan and overlooked by the US. The US was bashed as a destabilising actor in Afghanistan (an allegation that disturbed the US given its concerns over the Taliban's rise, which it considered just as unrepresentative a Pashtun entity as the Tajik-dominated Rabbani regime).[153] In contrast, Iran's former President Akbar Hashemi Rafsanjani was viewed as a 'harbinger of hope' and Russia a 'close friend'.[154]

Partisans emerged winners in 1996–97. Unlike 1992 when the Congress party, under Rao's leadership, had adjusted its Afghanistan policy to accommodate the Mujahideen, in 1996, most Congress leaders such as Pranab Mukherjee were openly advocating that to 'contain the Taliban is our only objective'.[155] The CPI, the CPI (M), and the BJP supported this stand.[156] In a plot dominated by oil politics, terrorism, strategic depth, ethnic tensions, and territorial disputes (Durand Line and Kashmir), the Taliban, Pakistan, and the US were the 'villains', and the Afghan government factions and other anti-Pakistan Afghan factions coupled with Iran and Russia were the 'heroes'. 'There was nobody who was doubting this policy [containing the Taliban]. Nothing was to be gained, in fact, everything was to be lost by showing the slightest signs of wanting to engage'.[157] Raghunath conveyed a similar message to Lakhdar Brahimi, the then Special Envoy to the UN Secretary General on Afghan Affairs, during the latter's visit to India on 12 September 1997.[158] The foreign secretary was categorical that 'all bastions of freedom in Afghanistan were demolished and [that] the Taliban was running riot, and they ran a kind of regime of atrocity'.[159] He argues that the Taliban would have treated recognition from India as a certificate to their 'Jihad ideology', which was much in contrast with secular Indian sensibilities. Strongly supporting Raghunath's line within the MEA was